the game, too, but entirely unharmed by the accident. Still, he only had to dismount to check on the injured player for ‘cries and lamentations’ to arise among the spectators and for ‘strife-mongers [to take] advantage of the opportunity’.[8] Badauni suggests that the emperor himself didn’t realize how dangerous the situation was until an older courtier grabbed his reins and said, ‘My Lord, what are you doing here? Go away!’ The courtier’s anxiety stemmed, presumably, from a fear that rumours might arise that Akbar, too, had been unhorsed and injured. Back in the palace, Akbar sent urgent assurances of his well-being across his realm, particularly to its frontiers, ‘so that the panic was stayed’.[9]

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If the emperor toppled, that is, so might his empire. And what if, as had now happened, Akbar went into an inexplicable trance? Would his empire collapse in an equal frenzy?

The news was particularly agitating in the newly conquered east, writes Badauni, as ‘strange rumours and wonderful lies became current in the mouths of the common people’. There were even insurrections, although ‘quickly quelled’.

This time, however, no messengers went hurtling in all directions with reassurances. Instead, there was more and more news of Akbar’s grand gestures and growing eccentricities, all of which followed, at ever grander scale, a pattern of symbolic actions that proclaimed the emperor’s care for his subjects, authority over his officers, and, of course, his growing saintliness, if not divinity.

Soon after his epiphanic haircut, Akbar ordered a spectacle that managed to combine all three ‘visions’ of himself in one. The great tank in Fatehpur, the Anup Talao, was to be filled to the brim with coins. One may gauge the scale of the enterprise by the fact that it was only half-completed when Raja Todar Mal reported that 17 crore dams[10] had already been poured into the massive tank. It took months to fill it all the way up. Finally, on 5 October 1578, Akbar inaugurated the distribution of the money. First, there was a prayer. Then, picking out ‘one by one a mohar, a rupee, and a dam’, the emperor handed them to selected mansabdars, Abul Fazl amongst them. They were to take the coins as an ‘amulet’, Akbar lectured, and make a